Rhythms of Black Culture

By Bonafide Rojas, Dan Sully and Ben Butter

Raise your hand if you've ever been laughed at...ever been stared at (maybe not you?)

Raise your hand if you've ever been ridiculed...called an "original" (nah, maybe not you)

Just-nod your head if you like who you are...and don't care what these other folks say about you

INTRODUCTION

In the early 1970s, times were tougher than usual for the poorer parts of urban America. From a whole lot of nothing—and a whole lot of imagination—Hip Hop took form. Then in the 1980s the birth of slam poetry coincided with the rise of the hip-hop culture.

So . . . what is Hip-Hop? Is it the music with a chest-thumping beat? The rapid-fire lyrics rapped into a handheld mic? Gravity-defying dance steps? Writers turning walls into canvases with larger-than-life letters and illustrations? Is it poetry?

The answer is, yes, all of the above—and more. Hip Hop has blended and transcended these artistic elements to become a means for celebrating, understanding, confronting, and commenting on life and the world. Hip Hop, in other words, is a way of living—a culture.

According to Amaranth Borsuk, assistant professor at the University of Washington, "The relationship of poets to performance has changed over time, based on what is popular and what's in vogue; but poetry is undeniably rooted in culture. And Hip-hop and Rap poetry, specifically in the black culture."

For your listening pleasure, I offer you the Rhythms of Black Culture through the poems In Front of the Class by Bonafide Rojas, Hips for the Hops by Dan Sully and Underdog by Ben Butter.

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In Front of the Class by Bonafide Rojas (Pg 11-14)

i'm standing in front of a class

society has deemed derelicts and hoodlums

and i am their teacher

i share with them the poem

that will save the world

and they say that it's got to be as good

as a nas rhyme and have more emotion

than tupac did

my class consisting
of ex-gang bangers, drug dealers, graffiti writers
and students who have traveled too much
in the cracks of the public school system
they are my students

and as their teacher
i have traveled as many roads
as they have, and stand in front
of them without fear
because they can smell fear

i am them eight years ahead
with poetry being the left turn i made at 17
i tell them that road is approaching
all they have to do is take that road
and run down it so fast that their past
will never catch up to them

i tell them in their metamorphosis
they can change their name
their place of rest, their life,
their career, their goals

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and strive for that that has seemed
unattainable for so many years
one student says "how"
it's easy for you to say it now
how the hell am i supposed to get there,
i have one kid, one gang after me, and no job,
how the hell am i supposed to go anywhere
besides down.

i ask him "how bad do you want it?"
in the beginning all i had was poetry
everything else took a back seat
girls, family, and work was a part time
that lasted *6* months with me getting
fired for writing on the job

i tell them to use their connections,
intern somewhere,
learn to live, live to write
love to learn, write to love

this is the last day of your life
what are you going to leave behind?

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what will be your legacy?
and they stare at me like
a rabbit in the headlights
and say they don't know

i tell them to open their chests
and let whatever falls out
let it fall on the page

let the page be
your doctor
your therapist
your lover

let the page be
your enemy, punch it in the face
the best friend that'll never stab you in the back
your prozac

let the page be your hip hop
your rock and roll
the fancy ride you're always talking about

let the page be

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the bling bling on your wrist
the underground beat your about to rip
your autobiography

tell them who you are
tell them they're wrong for labeling you
tell them your life may not be worth anything now
but tomorrow gives you hope
so you won't take your life today or the next day
tell them you will be here forever
tell them you are the future your parents have been
planning for
tell them you are the ones who create beautiful art from
stark realities
tell them you are loved
no matter what anyone says
tell them you are loved

and they write
head down for fifteen minutes
pen in hand
never coming off the page
no cares for grammar

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no cares for spelling
no cares for structure
never coming off the page
and the first student gets up
and his mouth open wide and says

"i want to live"
"i want to love"
(repeated a hundred times over)
"i want to live"
"i want to love"

and he asks me
if that was any good
and i tell him
it's the best poem
i've ever heard.

Hips for the Hop by Dan Sully (Pg 32-24)

There is nothing like the sound of a woman

spittin' freestyles
flicking tongue-verse rhythms

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clapping ears

Voice is gravity
feel the weight of words
The will of be-girl
because be-girls will be girls
jumping in break circles
busting windmills to make your headspin
getting crazy footloose
shaming Kevin Bacon

See, hip-hop is culture
and the cipher ain't complete
without a female's touch

this is to
the girl without polished nails
because spraypaint won't come off as easy
No acrylics on her hands
because it wrecks her can control

This is to
modern-day Aphrodite wayward warriors
Maya Angelou-type Phenomenal Women

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faces unfalsifed with masks for our masquerades

on the mean streets with a Mean Streak
Reciting lighting mics titely
Intensely spinning wrecking records
busting a six-step to be-girl pose

This is to the dreadlocked
head-wrapped hoodied out
homegrown
earth toned
lover, leader
poet, pixie
stylin', scholar
Queens of hip-hop

Underdog by Ben Butter (Pg 38-39)

I and my peers / we're / looked at as weirdoes
Cats with thir-teen holes / between nose, earlobes
Back in the 'hood, they'd ask why I rock weird clothes
Copped from thrift stores, about thirty years old
When you were young, were you the star of the freak show?
Liked words? Called a nerd, 'cause you read poems?
I've survived without brand names and beer jokes

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A different drum movin' your feet's soles
Our parents taught us, "Clothes don't make me"
Tell that the parents of the kids who named me
With no sticks, stones / advertising raped me
(I still take her calls...and still read her blogs ... and still play her songs)
There are so many, she plays the same old...nothin
Nah, I ain't hat-in' / on Wayne or Justin
Kanye, Miss Hudson / but pop songs
and dot-corns /are blindfolds when leaders drop bombs/ so ...

Raise your hand if you've ever been laughed at...ever been stared at (maybe not you?)
Raise your hand f you've ever been ridiculed...called an "original" (nah, maybe not you)
Just nod your head if you're an individual...and don't care what these other folks say about you

Do what *you do?* Yeah-I'd like to
But I was made *to do* / this thing that I do
If I were the type to / try to / act like you
There'd be <u>one less me</u> in the world

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They called us motormouths, they called us music
geeks
They called us bookworms, stupid jocks, athletes
They dissed the way we talked, if not the way we
dressed
'til it got popular (just take a guess)
Tryin' to make the image in our mirror / seem clearer
Nearer to seeing our true selves / to sing pictures
Paint lyrics, write dances, eat instruments
Underdogs-take chances, be different

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Bonafide Rojas, Ben Butter, and Dan Sully
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AWARD HISTORY

MN State Qualifier

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